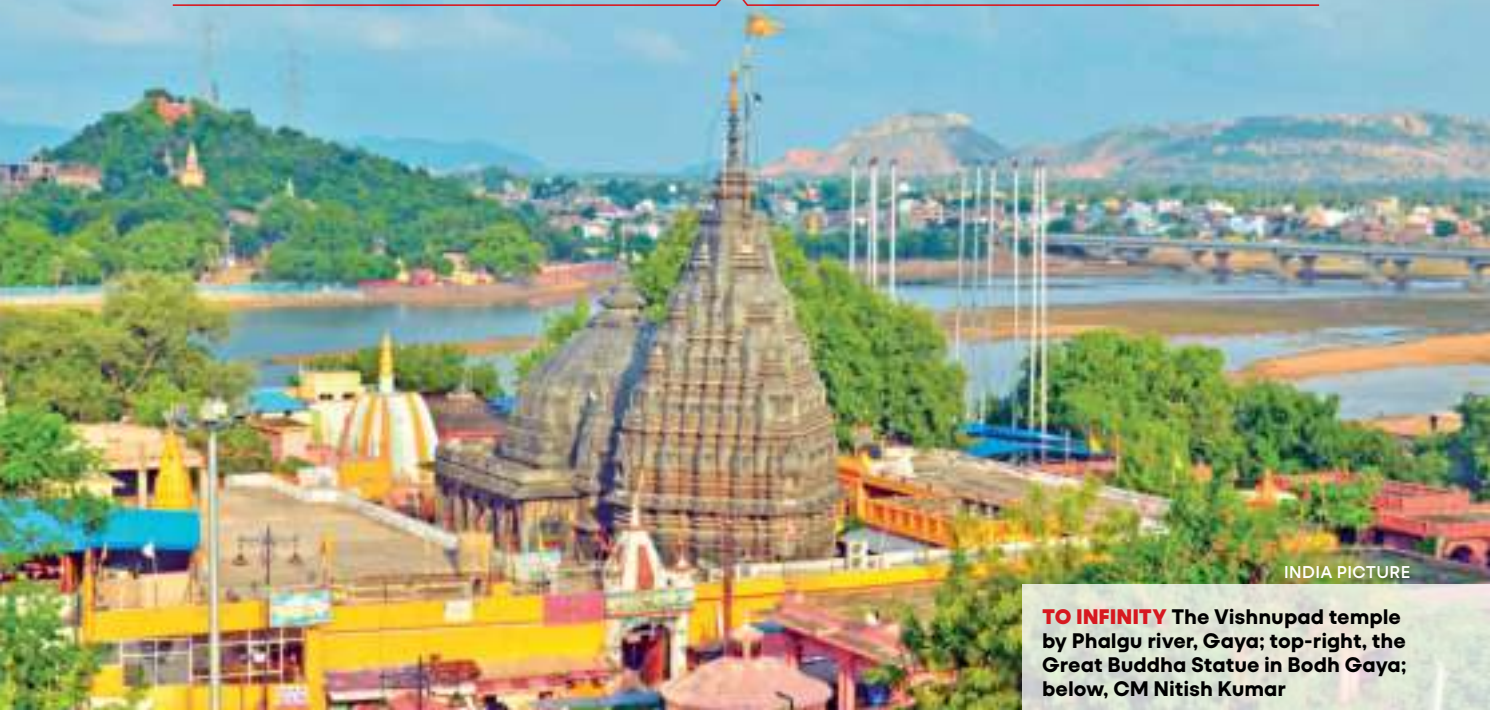
STATE SCAN

J&K: WATER AND IRE IN THE VALLEY *PG 22*

GUJARAT: RAZING AN ILLEGAL STORM *PG 24*



INDIA PICTURE

TO INFINITY The Vishnupad temple by Phalgu river, Gaya; top-right, the Great Buddha Statue in Bodh Gaya; below, CM Nitish Kumar

▶ BIHAR

NITISH PLAYS THE NAME GAME



RANJAN RAHI

Gaya changes its name to Gayaji, as renaming politics comes to Bihar. Nitish hasn't changed places with the BJP, yet. But his yielding maps an ongoing soil erosion

By **Amitabh Srivastava**

IN INDIA, AND IN GLOBAL SPACES TO WHICH its heritage speaks, the name 'Gaya' is a suffix in 'Bodh Gaya'—and evokes the Buddha. A place of silence, under a pipal by the banks of the Phalgu, where Gautama attained Buddhahood. Yet, on May 15, something ruffled that quietude. 'Gaya' was being renamed as 'Gayaji'. The whole district. No criticism came, not even from the Opposition, as the Nitish Kumar cabinet cleared this old rechristening proposal. Some, though, noticed a striking departure from Nitish's own record. In over 20 years at the helm of Bihar, he had never before approved the renaming of a single district. In yielding now, months short of an assembly election, he, too, has bathed in a different river.

For, Gaya has another layer of heritage, attached to Hindu belief and practice. In the city, 15 km north of Bodh Gaya, the banks of the Phalgu host the 18th century Vishnupad temple, built on a site swathed in sacred myth. On these sands, believers perform the *pind daan* to the departed: it's the final and holiest site prescribed for the